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Tourism and the blue economy

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ABSTRACT
The blue economy is formally recognized by the United Nations as a term that aims to develop a comprehensive understanding of economic activity that takes place within or through ocean and freshwater bodies of water. Optimally, the blue economy subscribes to sustainable economic principles and a set of guidelines to ensure the protection of all marine and freshwater resources and ecosystem services. All marine forms of tourism, coastal tourism and freshwater tourism activities are part of the blue economy and has made a significant contribution towards sustainable economic practices in these spaces. However, there is a lack of consensus about what the blue economy is, how it should be measured and how to regulate sustainable performances across multiple diverse sectors of activity. This presents tourism scholars with an opportunity to make a contribution to the development of this concept and to ensure that tourism related activities are sufficiently accounted for in the planning and policy development of blue economies around the world.

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Tourism; sustainability; blue Economy; oceans; united Nations

Introduction

With oceanic generated economic activity predicted to double by 2030, with a vast expansion of types and volume of ocean industrialisation, there has never been more interest in this space nor concern for its sustainability. The 'blue economy' is built upon this interest and concern seeking to better recognise the scope and scale of economic activity that takes advantage of oceans, to integrate policy and planning fundamentals and to measure the impact of these activities against sustainability goals. While proactive in the pursuit of sustainable economic development, two of the key drivers of this movement is the depletion of territorial resources resultant from less than sustainable development practice and the profound transformations to oceanic ecologies already taking place (Voyer et al., 2018). Therefore, the blue economy as it pertains to sustainable development is crucial not only in supporting current lifestyles and demands but in identifying new economic relations with natural resource use.

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Tourism has longstanding and significant economic relations with oceanic environments. Some of the earliest and most popular destinations reside in coastal areas and the industry is transformative of new ways of engaging with oceanic spaces as technologies open greater oceanic territory for these purposes. As sustainable marine tourism scholarship shows, tourism can simultaneously be a pioneer of human-ocean relations, a driver of innovation, a promoter of oceanic stewardship and coloniser and exploiter of this resource rich territory. Its substantial presence in coastal, oceanic and inland waterways, and in economic impact, make its role in shaping the blue economy an important one. A challenge in recognising what these roles may be is that there is little consensus about what the blue economy is, how to measure it and therefore, how to understand and mediate against the risks it poses to sustainable futures. Commensurately, while undoubtably a part of this blue economic conglomeration, the implications of this comprehensive framework on the operations and future of blue tourism activity remains unclear.

Two factors constitute the mainstay of UN treatise on the blue economy and these are the specification of oceanic territory and other inland waterways and the requirement of sustainability principles underpinning economic activity. Beyond these are many alternatives and nuances that remain open to interpretation. As a recent term, the 'blue economy' is still under negotiation and this includes finding a place for tourism and for tourism research. While many of the core concerns of the blue economy are discoverable in existing marine tourism scholarship, as the concept consolidates, it is anticipated that it will be useful for extending the field of tourism and better understanding the changing shape of the nature, planning and governance of tourism in oceanic and other watery environments. Notwithstanding humanity's existing and enduring relationship with blue economies, in this new space of emerging and accelerating economic activity are 'both openings as well as (en)closures allowing for the creation of new political organizations and institutions' (Ertör and Hadjimichael, 2020, p. 2). This chapter will examine the concept in greater detail and propose that both the imprecision of the term and its novelty in tourism scholarship opens multiple possibilities for the field to make a valuable and, arguably, much needed contribution.

History and development of the concept

The blue economy is a term that belongs to the twenty-first century but its precedents lie in the longer environmental movement. The origin of the term is accorded to the 2012 United Nations Conference on Sustainable Development held in Rio de Janeiro (UNEP, 2012). The blue economy builds upon the established sustainability paradigm and on attempts to unify the ocean in a comprehensive framework as with the UN Law of the Sea Treaty in 1982 (Voyer et al., 2018). The term represents a more planned approach to blue economies extending and adapting those principles inherent in the green economy to water, particularly oceanic, environments. In the case of international waters, the blue economy aims to better account for the distribution of shared (non-territorial) resources and within local waters the framework adopts, in principle, the same sustainability resolutions found on land, specifically, but not exclusively, linked to the UN Sustainable Development Goal of *Life Below Water*.

In its simplest terms, the blue economy specifies a spatial entity or territory in which to extend the requirement of 'de-coupling of socio-economic development from environmental degradation' (United Nations Conference on Trade & Development, 2014, p. 2). However, there is also acknowledgement that this territory is resistant to incorporating land-based planning, policy and practices, being fundamentally different in character. Still referred to as the oceanic frontier, the UN acknowledges specific challenges and requirements for different solutions in the governance of 'inherently fluid' domains. In this sense, the blue economy confers both a practical and epistemological challenge (Ertör & Hadjimichael, 2020).

In early UN discussions of the blue economy, a key driver was from small island states for whom the oceanic exclusive economic zones provide a larger 'territory' for generating economic activity than land. Representatives successfully argued for specific identification of oceanic terrain as linked to, but distinctive from, the term 'green economy' and its connotations with land. Many of these states are also subject to exploitation involving local compliance, governance and arrangements with offshore companies that can be environmentally detrimental. This is no less the case with tourism development that depends upon oceanic affordances in generating demand to these destinations. Some of the consequences of this have been examined in tourism scholarship particularly in the cases of cruise shipping operations, global resort development companies and 'blue grabbing' (Hampton et al. 2018).

At the more comprehensive scale of the blue economy, marine spatial planning is promoted to mainstream oceans-based economies into the United Nations Development Goals including the development of a system of global reporting. Within this context, the oceanic estate is mobilised as a global resource that requires a cooperative framework to guard against harmful nationally and regionally governed practices. Spalding (2016) takes the view that this emphasis on sustainability is part of what he terms the *new* blue economy, taking the term 'blue economy' for granted as descriptive of traditional and established oceanic economies. He claims that this new iteration of economic practice is far more diverse supporting emerging activities and technologies that are often invisible. Hence, the new blue economy is 'an attempt to create a unified, global definition of economic industries and activities that relate to the ocean in order to generate comprehensive and progressive economic health' (p. 5). This aligns with the EU Commission's 2021 strategic policy communique that explicitly refers to transitioning the European Union's 'blue growth economy' to a 'sustainable blue economy', and with the language of the US National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration and its emphasis on transitioning towards sustainability, knowledge and distribution.

Blue economic activities are described in multiple ways but generally are either *distinctive* from 'traditional' economic activities that take place on land or are seen as an *extension* of traditional economic activity into oceanic spaces. The latter view accords less agency to oceanic environments than the former and tends to regard specific challenges posed by oceanic spaces, like porous boundaries for legislature and governance, as obstacles to be overcome by consolidation with existing land-based operating systems. Where economic activities are conceived of as different to traditional land-based economic activity, the oceanic environment is accorded greater

agency in influencing economic activity and practice. This latter description is more nuanced but less often considered except within the growing body of 'blue' scholarship amongst the humanities and social sciences that begin from the position that oceanic environments cannot be too simply reconciled with land-based knowledge and practices. In the case of promoting blue growth, the blue economy signifies oceans as extended theatres of anthropocentric activity and practice rather than new or novel frontiers of action that require fundamentally different managerial practices and solutions. In tourism, the idea of oceanic economy occupies a middle position being both an extended domain of business-as-usual (land-based regulation and sustainability) while also acknowledging these spaces as unique destinations.

Smith-Godfrey's (2016) review of the definitions of the blue economy identifies five key activities associated with the term: the harvesting of living resources; the extraction of non-living resources; the generation of new resources; the trade of resources (shipping) and resource health (conservation and stewardship). *Prima facie*, these tend towards a classical approach to economic activities with only weak attendance to the tertiary sector that comprises the bulk of the tourism industry. Tourism is recognisable indirectly in making use of each of these activities and more explicitly playing a role in trade in the form of the cruise industry, the generation of new resources in the form of resort development and oceanic attractions and resource health in those places where tourism explicitly seeks to generate awareness, appreciation and stewardship for oceanic ecosystems.

Spalding (2016) takes a different view categorising economic activity into traditional and new activities while maintaining that the measure of success is sustainability. In this schema, tourism is accounted for as an established activity while newer activities, of which there is still very little data, include carbon storage and sequestration, blue biotechnologies, restoration projects, renewable energy and seabed mining. As an established activity within the blue economy and one that is already subject to sustainable ideals, a key question becomes how these new activities will impact or share the space with tourism.

The 2018 *Sustainable Blue Economy Conference* hosted by Kenya, Japan and Canada deployed nine categories for analysing the framework: shipping; employment; cities; energy; marine life; food security; climate change; maritime security and culture. In this case, categories are not based on sectors or activities but services and challenges that characterise blue economic activity. Here again there is no specific reference to tourism and sectors like fishing and aquaculture, wind farming and transport are emphasised. This consistent de-emphasis of tourism in defining the blue economy is both a challenge and opportunity for tourism researchers to address.

Current trends related to the blue economy and tourism

Current trends are influenced by the status of oceanic environments as poorly understood. Alongside the formidable vastness of this territory and its digression from land-based rhythms and norms, this poses a significant yet pressing challenge for advancing sustainable economic practices. Access to undersea exploration in submersibles began a short one hundred and fifty years ago and scuba technology is a post WW2 phenomenon. Large swathes of the deep ocean remain invisible

and the marine sciences did not fully develop until the mid-twentieth century. Knowledge production is highly dependent on technological advancement and this inaccessibility as well as our historical lack of familiarity with aqueous environments makes the task of governing and managing oceans fraught and immense. These characterisations, while problematic for sustainable planning and management, have also established oceanic places as mythical worlds of strangeness, novelty and fascination. In turn, this has made them, and proximity to them, classical attractors for tourists, forming the basis of an enduring relationship between the sea and the tourism industry. Consequently, the existing legacy of sustainable marine tourism research anticipates many of the concerns and principles now promoted in describing the blue economy. Explicit linking of the two domains is beginning to emerge as within the realms of surfing ecosystem evaluation (Manero & Mach, 2023). There are many ways in which tourism and the blue economy can attune to each other more closely.

As an umbrella term for all forms of oceanic economic development and activity, or translating oceans into 'development spaces', the blue economy can be particularly useful for managing parallel or competing economic activities (Voyer et al., 2018). The case of fishing and tourism is well understood in this regard however inroads into mining, more invasive forms of seabed cultivation and energy generation are transforming oceanic economies into more diverse and crowded spaces both above and beneath the surface. As climate change drives the replacement of fossil fuels, for example, oceanic spaces are becoming particularly attractive sources of alternative wind and wave generated energy. As oceans become more valued for these affordances described as 'downstream activities' like low carbon energy generation and deep-sea water extraction for commercial purposes, 'upstream activities', such as tourism, will see the reshaping of existing tourism geographies (Spalding, 2016). This may take the form of offering lower carbon forms of energy and greening destinations while potentially impacting coastal developments and aesthetics with offshore windfarms for example. The blue economy, especially if it fulfils UN objectives of setting multilateral governance criteria and guidelines, will play an important role in negotiating these transformations. It is in this sense, as a unifying concept, capable of taking account of the broad range of blue economic activity, that a more formalised relationship begins to develop between marine tourism and the blue economy.

The term 'blue economy' is also interchangeable with 'oceans economy' and this accords with the scope of marine tourism. However, the UN stipulates that the term is not to be taken to exclude inland and freshwater environments like rivers, lakes, canals and estuaries. Despite this, most of the scholarship that describes and defines the blue economy does so in purely oceanic terms. This itself poses a problem in defining the scope of the economy, especially as inland waterways are subject to equal, and in some cases more, environmental pressure and are no less important to sustaining planetary life. A narrowed, exclusively oceanic, definition of the blue economy removes any benefits of this coordinated approach from these freshwater ecologies and resources. Many inland waterways contribute towards the tourism economy as reserves of fresh water, habitats for wildlife, amenities to destination towns and cities and as destinations in themselves. Reasserting their importance in accordance

with the UN definition of blue economies is both pressing and something that tourism researchers can contribute towards.

The blue economy is a twenty-first century concept that aims to create a comprehensive data base, policy arena and planning framework for managing economic activity in blue environments sustainably. As with its precedent 'green economy' the term attracts similar critiques that are worthy of tourism scholarly focus. Like the green economy, the blue economy embodies two contradictory and perhaps irreconcilable demands. On the one hand it aims to promote and advance economic growth through oceanic resources and on the other to promote capitalist market protection of the oceanic estate from existing and projected environmental devastation (Voyer et al., 2018). In the proclaimed UN Decade of Ocean Science for Sustainable Development (2021–2030), the question of whether technologies can ultimately de-couple environmental degradation in the service of growth or whether degrowth, circularity or stabilisation is the better solution is vitally applicable to the seventy-one percent of the Earth's watery volume (Ertör & Hadjimichael, 2020). As with all current debates and trends permeating the challenges and opportunities of sustainable development more generally, tourism in practice and in scholarship has a vital role to play.

Gaps in the literature and future research directions

While the blue economy seeks to create a comprehensive framework for oceanic related economic activity and, in its fullest sense, to find a way to measure the sustainability of these, there remains a sectoral approach to the research. Across this is an emphasis on traditional economic activities like fishing and trade (shipping) and, then, on newer economic activities making use of technological advancements of the types mentioned above. Sustainable marine tourism research is an example of the sectoral approach to research but, bewilderingly, in policy documents concerned with the blue economy there is sense that tourism is an afterthought. Martínez Vázquez et al. (2021, p. 94) explain this as resulting from both a lack of data to define a relationship between tourism and the broader set of economic activities related to the sea and, most problematically, from a classical definition of economics that favours resource extraction and harvesting. While all key strategic documents include marine and coastal tourism, it is not prominent in describing and analysing blue economic activity. Instead, a narrowed understanding of economic activity promotes fishing and other oceanic resource harvesting as well as mining and energy production over the economies generated by tourism, sport, leisure and recreation. This is notable even in the case of small island states and other destinations where oceanic tourism is a significant contributor to net economic performance. The lack of understanding about the relationship of tourism to other economic activity means that, for example, while oceanic restoration and sustainability goals are set a high priority, there is a failure to recognise the cases where tourism plays a key role in enabling and supporting this. Instead ocean restoration stands apart as a separate industry sector in a move that undermines the very noble desire to establish a more comprehensive, and therefore interconnected, view of oceanic economic activities. It may be that the focus on more obviously extractive industries suggests little appreciation of the role that tourism

plays in both depleting oceanic resources and threatening ecological services, but this also undervalues the role it can play in promoting more harmonious relations with these same environments. Regardless, it is a shortcoming of a platform that promotes a comprehensive understanding and assessment of current blue economic activity.

In Australia, for example, policy considerations towards the blue economy is dominated by traditionally recognised extractive industries like mining and aquaculture and emerging technologies like energy generation. Unlike strategic policy statements in the European Union, there is little to no recognition of the varied economy generated through tourism and leisure in oceanic places and the important role that this kind of activity can play in developing ocean stewardship as noted in places like the Barrier Reef and many small island destinations. The Australian Government's Blue Economy Research Centre boasts forty-four partners contributing to 'opportunities to grow the blue economy'. Not one of these partners are related to tourism, leisure and recreation and the centre's research programmes are concentrated exclusively on offshore engineering and technology; seafood and marine products; offshore renewable energy systems, environment and ecosystems, and sustainable offshore developments. This is despite the significance of the tourist sector to the Australian economy with Australian beaches and the Barrier Reef occupying two of the top three tourist attractors, with seventy per cent of international visitors reportedly enjoying aquatic and coastal experiences and ranking Australia first for marine wildlife, remote and developed coastal beaches and aquatic locations (Tourism Australia, 2023).

Elsewhere, there is some recognition of tourism's role in pioneering sustainable blue economic initiatives. A recent example is UN General-Secretary Zurab Pololikashvilli's (2023) article extolling the innovative practices flourishing in coastal destinations where coastal resorts contribute to both green (land) and blue (ocean) sustainability mission statements. In another practical recent example of oceanic restoration through tourism, a growing number of destinations spanning the oceans of Europe, Asia, the Americas and Australia are employing novel techniques to restore oceanic substrata and grow and protect adjacent reef systems through artwork attractions as artificial reefs. These not only extend the range of corals, reef growth and nutrients for sea-life but attract tourists away from natural formations, reducing pressure from visitation and encouraging environmental stewardship through developing memorable and lasting experiences with oceanic ecologies (see DeLoughrey, 2017). At a policy level, the UN Global Tourism Plastics Initiative is aimed at strengthening the tourism and circular economies to reduce plastic waste (among others) that are an increasingly visible detrimental source of oceanic degradation (https://www.unwto.org/sustainable-development/global-tourism-plastics-initiative).

Future research can also contribute towards the innovative potential of water in thinking and acting. Oceans are notable as world spaces, in some parts belonging to no territorial entities. In this, and a myriad of ways, they are understood as special places with distinctive qualities that separate them from land where most of our ideas about governance, planning and management are generated. Consequently, when it comes to defining the economy that takes place there, there is little consensus and a number of challenges that have no precedent. Acknowledgement in UN documentation that there are inherent differences between land, coastal and oceanic environments is particularly useful to scholars of marine tourism since it encourages

a stronger focus on what makes tourism within water worlds inherently different to tourism practice on land and learning from these rather than forcing land-based precedents into these spaces regardless of suitability (Picken, 2021). Permission to say that the blue economy (and tourism) does not operate in precisely the same way as economies on land, means more can be learned about marine tourism operations and their connectedness to onshore activity and support. There is greater potential to integrate the blue economy with 'blue tourism' centring the 'sea as protagonist' in describing and analysing tourist activities within these environments (Martinez Vázquez et al., 2021).

Conclusion

There is lack of consensus about what the blue economy is and how, and to what extent, it will reshape our understanding and economic practices in the future. This lack of clarity impacts tourism and the implications of a more comprehensive framework for guiding and governing the use of oceanic resources upon the tourism industry and tourist demand. It is long established, even before the sustainability paradigm, that tourism must protect the places upon which it depends so there is nothing overly new in the general principles attached the sustainable application of blue economic frameworks. What may be more impactful is the way in which the blue economy provides a platform for linking up disparate activities and exclusive, yet porous, economic zones under an umbrella set of principles that are currently emerging. The fluidity and porosity that has characterised oceanic boundaries, planning and governance are set to be subject to a more consolidated approach into the future.

With greater attention and activity taking place in blue spaces, as resources continue to deplete and as knowledge of the environments that make up the greater volume of our blue planet develops at pace, the multifaceted role of tourism within, upon and against these spaces becomes ever more important. Drawing on the blue economy as a conceptual resource has the potential to assist scholars and industry to better connect with adjacent blue industry outcomes, to understand, prepare for and respond to the transformations that are taking place within blue spaces and to take up more space in discussions that currently under appreciate the enduring presence of tourism within water worlds and its potential to transform them for the better or worse.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

Notes on contributor

Felicity Picken has a special interest in methodologies that are loosely described as "disorganized thinking" as influenced by unconventional styled lines of inquiry. Her research focuses on the interdisciplinary study of tourism and she has applied her thinking to the development of tourism knowledge, our relations with the oceanic realms of the blue planet and the development of place with a focus on tourism, architecture, art and the creative and cultural economies.

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